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Make 1: Reverse-engineer a DH/AI project

- Make: Choose one DH or AI project from the list I provide here. Explore how it was built (read documentation, look at credits, note the tools). Create a one-page sketch (diagram, bullet notes, or visual map) reverse-engineering how the project might work.
- Reflect: What counts as "making" in this case? What happens when machines are part of the making? Follow these prompts:

Week 1 Make: Reverse-Engineering a DH / AI Project
Your goal is not to understand everything technically.
Your goal is to ask good questions about how a project is made.
Project Chosen:
Photogrammar https://photogrammar.org/maps

1. What Is Being Made?

- What is the *output* of this project?
  (Map, image, network, visualization, text, interface, etc.)

The output for this project is a collection of vintage photographs sorted by county across the United States.

- What experience does it create for the user?

As a user, I found this very well organized as it has a map interface as well as a zoom function so that you can navigate and sort by category for photos. I thought the light versus dark shading on the counties was interesting so that you can see how many photos there are for that area. There is also a way to sort it by cities and towns.

2. What Is the Project Made *From*? (Data)

  - What counts as "data" here?

The data in this project are the photos, which are sorted by region.

  - Where does it come from?

The data, or photos, in this project come from a database of 170,000 photographs taken by the U.S. government (FSA and OWI specifically) between 1935 and 1943. It is based a the University of Richmond. The Library of Congress had contributions.

- What seems missing or excluded?

It is a very specific time in history which is less than a decade, so there is lots of history that could be added as well. Additionally, much of the midwest has missing counties with zero photographs, and some areas on the East and West coasts have plenty of photographs. Adding more photographs (if they were taken) would make this more complete.

3. Tools, Algorithms, or Systems

- What software, platforms, or models are involved?

GIS is used, which is one of the platforms used for map-based interfaces. Additionally, the archive at the Library of Congress was used for the photographs. Open-access digital content was used and a transportation map of the U.S. was used to make the interface.

- Is AI used? If yes, where in the process?

Yes, AI was used for Photogrammar, which was a goal for organizing the database.

- What steps feel automated vs. guided?

Most of the interface is user-directed, which I found interesting. There was not a lot of guidance or automation from the website itself.

- **4. Human Labor & Decisions**
- Who likely collected the data?

Lauren Tilton and Taylor Arnold began the project in 2010 (graduate student in American Studies and a doctoral candidate, respectively). They worked with others over time as well.

- Who cleaned, categorized, or interpreted it?

Here is a list of project contributors.

Trip Kirkpatrick - project manager

Peter Leonard - lab experiments

Laura Wexler - PI

Courtney Rivard, Lauren Tilton, and Taylor Arnold also contributed.

- Where do you see *human judgment* shaping the outcome?

I noticed the titles of the photographs typically explain what takes place in them, but I wonder if this was done by AI or by humans. If it was done by humans, then there was room for human judgment.

5. Design as Argument

- How do visual or interface choices shape meaning?

I think that using the map interface is a large part of the way it looks and is, and because you can sort by county, people will be drawn to counties familiar to them. This can shape meaning by showing which counties people are clicking on and, therefore, which photos people are viewing. The titles of the photographs are also an interesting part of the presentation, and some of them are really beautiful, such as “Off to a New Start”. I wonder why they chose the color scheme that they did.

- What does the project make easy to see?

I think the way the counties are shaded helps determine where the most photographs are taken, and this gives the user a shortcut to seeing how many by viewing the map.

- What does it make hard to see?

I didn’t know the names of the counties I was interested in, so I was curious to see if they would ever organize it another way. I know they also did a cities/towns format with dots, which is an alternative.

Reflection (200–300 words)
What counts as “making” in this project?
What changes when machines participate in making?
You should respond in paragraph form.
📌 **Format**

- One page maximum

- You can upload a google doc or write everything directly here. Diagram, sketch, bullets, or visual map welcome

The “making” that was done in Photogrammar would be the way it is organized, collected, categorized, and placed on a map. Much of this work was done by AI. The goal of this project, as project leader Lauren Tilton said, was to make these photographs that typically remain in the Library of Congress more accessible to the people (https://impact.richmond.edu/digital-humanities.html). This is a very interesting project to me because I find history fascinating, and this project was able to broadcast these photos to a wider audience by putting them on a public website interface. This would normally be a very arduous project if people had to sort each of these photos individually by hand, but using machines to help in the process gives people the ability to do a project like this much quicker. Photogrammar has a map interface that allows the user to navigate to their county, town, or city of interest to see the photos taken there from the years 1935-1943. I would not have originally guessed that AI was involved in the making of this project, because it could have technically been done by humans alone, but it seems like they used AI to speed up the process of each photo being sorted onto the website.